

THE MEMORY EXCAVATION WORKSHEET

Some scenes aren't stuck because of craft. They're stuck because the truth they need is still living in you, unused.

A foreign exchange student once lived with a family for a year — ate at their table, argued about football, became part of the fabric of daily life the way only someone genuinely present can. About three months before he was due to leave, he grew quieter. A little harder to reach. Small frictions appeared that hadn't been there before.

He was leaving early — not in three months, but now, in the only way that made the real leaving survivable. He was making the goodbye bearable by beginning it alone, quietly, before anyone else knew it had started. No one ever said this out loud. It was simply understood, and then he was gone, and it was never forgotten.

Years later, a scene between two old friends — one of them moving away — kept coming out flat, and there was no obvious reason why. And then the memory of that quiet, early goodbye walked back into the room, and the scene arrived whole.

This worksheet is that sequence, laid out so you can run it yourself. It isn't a technique for inventing detail. It's a way of noticing what you already know — because you lived some version of it once, and it never entirely left you.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Find somewhere quiet enough to sit with a question longer than feels natural. This works best without a deadline attached to it. You are not trying to finish quickly. You are trying to let something arrive that wasn't already sitting on the surface.

There are five movements below. Move through them in order. Don't skip ahead to the scene — the memory has to come first, or there's nothing new for the scene to be built from.

1 The Scene That Won't Come Alive

Which scene keeps resisting you? Not the whole manuscript — one moment. Who's in it, and what's happening on the surface?

2 What Hasn't Been Admitted

Pick one character in that scene. What is this character feeling that they haven't admitted to themselves yet? Write the first answer that arrives — it's probably reasonable, and probably too quick to be the real one.

Now push once more. How long has this been building, underneath what the character is actually saying and doing in the scene?

3 Let a Memory Walk In

Sit with what you just wrote. Don't reach for it — let it come to you. Is there a person you've known, a memory you haven't thought about in years, a moment from your own life that rhymes with what this character is feeling? It doesn't have to match the plot. It only has to match the feeling.

4 What It Gave You

What did you understand, in that memory, that you never said out loud at the time? What would you have wanted to say, if you'd had the words for it then?

5 The Scene, Now

Return to where you started. Write the exchange again — two to six lines — carrying what you just found, even if you don't say it directly. Let the unspoken thing shape what's said, the way it shaped you.

WHAT JUST HAPPENED

AI didn't find what changed this scene. A memory did. The method's only job was to ask the right question long enough that the memory had room to arrive. That memory has always been your material — it just hadn't been asked for yet.

This is the same sequence Write Living Characters: A Fiction Writer's Masterclass teaches for every character, every wound, every line of dialogue that's been waiting on the surface for the right question to pull it down to where it lives.